THEGAPBRIEF · SIDE REPORT · NOVEMBER 4, 2026

Copying Custom Esignature: How Hard, and What Bots It Takes



A team email signature manager is easy to demo and hard to ship well. The editor is a weekend's work. Getting signatures into every Gmail and Outlook mailbox, and passing Google's and Microsoft's security reviews, is the real project. The market is also crowded with cheap, established tools.

Assigned by Jacob Peterson · Research. Checked Nov 4, 2026. Prices come from each vendor's own page unless noted. Customer counts and growth claims are the vendors' own, attributed as such. Build times and difficulty ratings are **[Estimate]**. This report gives no market size or revenue projections.

SUMMARY Bottom line

1 Verdict: medium to build, hard to ship, hard to win

Difficulty [Estimate]: 6/10 overall. The editor, templates, hosting, a team dashboard and click analytics are routine web work, about 3–5 weeks for a bot team. The hard 40% is deployment: writing signatures into Gmail needs a *restricted* Google scope (yearly CASA assessment), and Microsoft has *no Graph API for Outlook signatures*, so you need an Outlook add-in or mail routing through your own servers.

Biggest hurdle: trust and distribution, not code. You need Google verification plus CASA, Microsoft publisher verification and admin consent, and rendering that holds up in classic Outlook. Then you're competing with CodeTwo and Exclaimer at about $1 a user per month.

Bots needed: 5 (PM, Builder, Integrations, QA/Render, Growth & Support). That's a deliberately lean team, after the usage report showed chat between bots is the main usage cost.

Custom Esignature pricing · Google: Gmail API scopes · Microsoft Q&A: no Graph API for signatures

1 What Custom Esignature sells

1.1 Animated, "interactive" signatures, with a team dashboard on top

The homepage pitches "AI Email Signatures." Its headline features are AI Logo Animation, an interactive nav bar, an animated profile photo, a "verification badge," mobile responsiveness, Active Directory sync, bulk creation, server hosting, pro templates, a signature manager, a drag-and-drop visual editor and analytics (impressions and clicks). The site says it works with "ANY email or CRM," Gmail and Outlook included, and lists industry and role landing pages (real estate, healthcare, lawyers, realtors and more).

Deliverability claims: it says it never changes the email body, hosts assets on "high-trust domains" and CDNs, uses clean HTML/CSS, and uses no tracking pixels. Animations are served from its own servers.

customesignature.com (homepage, Features, Deliverability, FAQ)

1.2 Pricing (their own page)

Plan	Price	What it includes
Free	$0, "forever"	Starter templates, static icons and photo, a "Sent with Custom Esignature" watermark
Pro (1 signature)	$96/yr billed yearly (quarterly also offered; yearly "save 20%")	Animation, interactive icons, verification badge, no watermark, analytics, Outlook and Gmail sync, team dashboard
Enterprise	Contact us	100+ signatures, department segmentation, dedicated onboarding

The pricing page sizes plans by "how many signatures you need." The FAQ mentions a 7-day trial, and the pricing card says "14-Day Risk-Free Guarantee." The site isn't consistent about this.

app.customesignature.com/pricing · FAQ

1.3 Their own claims (not verified)

The site claims "50k+ users," "1000+ supported email or CRM," a "42% increase" in reply rate and "3X" link clicks. The About page calls it "a multimillion-dollar software used by over 50,000 professionals and brands" and names founder Evan Nicolini. None of these figures has an independent source, so they're reported only as claims. Note that a "1000+ platforms" claim usually means "paste the HTML into any client," not 1,000 integrations.

customesignature.com/about

1.4 The ad Jacob saw

The link's tracking tags show a Facebook paid campaign named "USA [ABO] – CES Nov 3, 2026," with the creative "Your whole team · Ellen VO · v02." That reads as a US ad set on ad-set budgets (ABO), an "Ellen" voiceover, version 2 **[Interpretation]**. I couldn't load the ad's own text: Meta's Ad Library needs a logged-in browser and wasn't read for this report. The "Your whole team" angle fits their move from single signatures to team plans (Team Dashboard, bulk creation, AD sync). Their Facebook page also promotes managing signatures for a whole team.

UTM parameters in the link Jacob shared · Custom Esignature on Facebook · Meta Ad Library search (open to view live ads)

2 Competitors and their prices

Product	Published price	Notes
CodeTwo Email Signatures 365	$1.22/user/mo yearly at 10–25 users, down to $0.73 at 500 (monthly billing $1.36–$0.81). 10-license minimum	Microsoft 365 only. Cloud (server-side) and Outlook add-in modes. Microsoft 365 Certified. Claims 140k+ companies
Exclaimer	Starter $0.90, Standard $1.45, Pro $1.75 /user/mo, billed annually. 10-user minimum	Microsoft 365 and Google. SOC 2 Type II and ISO 27001 cited on its trust page
WiseStamp	Basic $19/mo, Grow $49/mo, Platform $189/mo, Enterprise quoted. Pro+ for micro-teams at $2/mo per extra member	Google Workspace and Entra sync. Server-side only on Platform and up. 14-day trial
Newoldstamp	$109/yr for 5 signatures (about $1.80 per signature per month), sliding scale to 200+	Google Workspace and M365 integration, banner campaigns, analytics. 7-day trial. Claims 8,000+ businesses

Sigstr / Terminus (DemandScience Email Experiences)	No published price, quoted inside DemandScience contracts	sigstr.com and terminus.com now redirect to demandscience.com (per third-party reviews)
Newer entrants	e.g. AutoSignature $99/$299/$799 a month flat (its own page). Opensense $1/$3/$5 a user with a $500 monthly minimum (per AutoSignature)	Several new tools (AutoSignature, Signkit, emailfooter, Signatoro) published comparison pages in 2026. The niche is active and crowded

What this means: team signatures already cost about $1 a user per month at the market leaders. Custom Esignature's $96 a year for one signature is about 6–8× that per seat, and it justifies the gap with animation and "interactive" flair aimed at solo professionals and small teams, not with IT features.

CodeTwo pricing · Exclaimer pricing · WiseStamp pricing · Newoldstamp pricing · AutoSignature: Sigstr after Terminus · Signkit: Sigstr status

3 The technical build, piece by piece

3.1 Signature editor and templates · Difficulty 2/10 [Estimate]

A form-plus-preview editor (name, title, photo, logo, links, socials, banner) that outputs table-based HTML with inline CSS. Drag and drop is nice to have. "AI" can mean generating a layout and palette from a logo or website URL, which is one LLM call plus templates.

General practice.

3.2 HTML that renders everywhere · Difficulty 6/10 [Estimate]

Classic Outlook for Windows renders with Word's engine, so you need tables, inline styles, no flexbox or grid and fixed image sizes. Animated GIFs may play only the first frame in some Outlook versions, so the first frame of an "animated logo" must look finished. Gmail removes `<style>` blocks in some contexts, and Gmail caps signature length, so long HTML can be rejected. Dark mode can invert colors. Hover effects (their "interactive nav bar") don't work in most clients. Plan a test matrix: Gmail web and app, Outlook classic, new Outlook, Mac, iOS Mail.

Can I email (client support tables) · Gmail Help: signatures (character limit)

3.3 Gmail deployment (Google Workspace) · Difficulty 7/10 [Estimate]

The standard approach is the Gmail API `users.settings.sendAs.update`, which sets the signature for each user. Org-wide, an admin grants **domain-wide delegation** to your service account so you can write every user's signature, and directory data (names, titles) comes from the Admin SDK Directory API. The catch: the needed scope, `gmail.settings.basic`, is listed by Google as a **restricted** scope. Public apps need restricted-scope verification, and apps that store or move restricted data on servers need a third-party CASA security assessment, renewed every year. Google says unverified apps using restricted scopes are capped at 100 users.

CASA cost (sourced): Google says assessor fees run $500–$4,500 depending on complexity, and that tier-2 assessments take 2–3 weeks. TAC Security lists AL1 Basic at $675, and Secusy lists AL1 from $499 and AL2 at $5,400.

Google: Gmail API scopes (restricted list) · Gmail API: sendAs.update · Google: verification and CASA (fees, 100-user cap) · TAC Security CASA pricing · Secusy CASA pricing

3.4 Microsoft 365 / Outlook deployment · Difficulty 8/10 [Estimate]

No signature API. Microsoft Q&A answers say signatures can't be managed through Graph, and Graph's `mailboxSettings` has no signature field. Exclaimer adds that EWS, which some tools used to write signatures, is blocked by default from Oct 1, 2026 and shuts down fully in April 2027. `Set-MailboxMessageConfiguration` stops applying once roaming signatures are on. That leaves three routes:

(a) **Outlook add-in with event-based activation**: `OnNewMessageCompose` plus `body.setSignatureAsync` (requirement set 1.10). It works across web, new Outlook, classic Windows, Mac and mobile, but handlers get at most 60 seconds, and admins must deploy it centrally. (b) **Server-side**: an Exchange Online connector plus mail flow rule that routes outbound mail through your cloud, which stamps the signature on every device. This is CodeTwo's "cloud mode," and it's the heaviest to run because you're in the mail path (uptime, TLS, loops, deliverability). (c) **Transport-rule disclaimer HTML**: built in and free, but limited (it's appended at the bottom, under the reply chain).

Consent: a multi-tenant Entra app needs a verified publisher, and application permissions (reading the directory with `User.Read.All`) need tenant admin consent. Microsoft 365 App Compliance certification, which CodeTwo advertises, is optional but is what IT buyers look for.

Microsoft Q&A: signatures not in Graph · Exclaimer: Graph, EWS and roaming signatures · Microsoft Learn: event-based activation · Microsoft sample: set signature · Microsoft Learn: publisher verification

3.5 "Sync anywhere" without integrations · Difficulty 2/10 [Estimate]

For solo users and other clients (Apple Mail, Yahoo, CRMs), copy-paste install guides with a "copy signature" button cover most of it, and that's what "works with any email or CRM" usually means. A Chrome extension that inserts the signature in Gmail compose is a middle option that avoids restricted scopes.

General practice.

3.6 Hosting, analytics and banners · Difficulty 3/10 [Estimate]

Images and animated GIFs go on a CDN under your own domain. Click analytics come from redirect links (`/c/<id>`). Impressions need an image request, which is effectively a tracking pixel, and Custom Esignature says it uses no tracking pixels, so be careful what you claim. Apple Mail Privacy Protection and Gmail's image proxy also make open counts unreliable. Banners are a scheduled image plus a link per department.

Apple: Mail Privacy Protection

3.7 Team dashboard, directory sync and billing · Difficulty 4/10 [Estimate]

Workspaces, roles, departments, template assignment and bulk CSV import, plus directory sync from the Google Admin SDK or Microsoft Graph users (which is fine for reading profiles). Seat-based Stripe billing. Standard SaaS work.

General practice.

4 Build plan [Estimate]

Phase	Scope	Time (bot team)	Difficulty

0 · Validate	Pick a niche (see section 6). Landing page, waitlist, 10 customer calls	1 wk	1/10
1 · Solo MVP	Editor, 10 original templates, hosted images, copy-paste installs, click analytics, free tier with watermark, Stripe	3–4 wks	3/10
2 · Teams	Dashboard, departments, CSV bulk create, employee self-edit link, banners	2–3 wks	4/10
3 · Google	Workspace Marketplace app, domain-wide delegation, sendAs push, directory sync. OAuth verification and CASA run in parallel	3–4 wks build plus several weeks of review	7/10
4 · Microsoft	Event-based Outlook add-in, Entra app with publisher verification, admin-deploy guide. Server-side routing only later, if ever	4–6 wks	8/10
5 · Trust	Security page, DPA, SOC 2 readiness (only if selling to IT)	Ongoing	6/10

A sellable solo and small-team product takes about 6–8 weeks (phases 1–2). Full Gmail and Outlook automation takes about 4–5 months including reviews. These are estimates, and Google's and Microsoft's review timelines aren't in our control. Known fixed costs: CASA at about $500–$5,400 a year (sourced above), plus the Microsoft partner and publisher-verification setup.

Estimates. CASA figures from Google, TAC Security and Secusy, linked in 3.3.

5 The bot team

This is modeled on how Jacob's existing teams split PM, backend, web and QA work, but kept to 5 bots with one shared state file. The bots hand off work and flag blockers only, with no status pings (see the usage side report).

Bot	Owns	Doesn't do
PM	Roadmap, phase gates, the shared state file, verification paperwork checklists, Jacob decision requests	Relay messages between bots
Builder	Next.js app, editor, templates, dashboard, Stripe billing, CDN and analytics redirects (Supabase + Vercel)	Google or Microsoft auth
Integrations	Google OAuth, domain-wide delegation, sendAs push, Admin SDK sync. Outlook add-in, Entra app and Graph user sync. The CASA and publisher-verification submissions (Jacob signs)	UI work
QA / Render	Client rendering matrix (Gmail, Outlook classic and new, Apple, mobile, dark mode), screenshot tests, pre-CASA OWASP checks, regression tests before deploys	Ship code to main
Growth & Support	Original landing copy, niche pages, Meta and Google ad drafts (nothing posts without Jacob's approval), help docs, install guides, support inbox triage	Copy or paraphrase competitor copy

Team design. Approval rule per Jacob's standing instruction on posting.

6 How to win instead of copying

6.1 Angles worth testing [Idea, untested]

1) **Price clarity for teams of 3–25:** the leaders have 10-seat minimums (CodeTwo, Exclaimer), so a flat small-team price fills a real gap. 2) **Vertical packs with compliance built in:** real estate license numbers, legal and financial disclaimers, HIPAA-safe healthcare footers, all as template fields. 3) **Honest analytics:** clicks only, no pixels, stated plainly. 4) **Agency mode:** one dashboard for many client brands, resold white-label. 5) **Outlook-first for small Microsoft shops,** using the add-in route, which still avoids mail routing.

Based on the published minimums and plans in section 2.

6.2 Legal and IP cautions

Don't reuse their copy, template designs, animations, screenshots, names ("AI Logo Animation™" is marked as a trademark on their site) or the "verification badge" look. Write original copy and design original templates. Don't name them in ads, and keep comparison claims factual and sourced. A "verified" badge that doesn't verify anything is a consumer-protection risk, so only use the word if you actually verify the domain. Tracking or "impression" claims need a privacy policy that matches. Follow CAN-SPAM in promotional banners, and follow Google's and Microsoft's data policies (minimal scopes, deletion on request). This isn't legal advice, so get a lawyer's review before launch.

Custom Esignature pricing page (™ marks) · FTC: advertising and marketing guidance · Google API Services User Data Policy

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